co-operated with the Americans was seen, by the insurgents, as collaborating with the enemy. Suicide bombings and kidnappings became daily occurrences. Some of those kidnapped were foreigners, especially Americans and British, but most were Iraqis, often taken captive so that large sums of money could be extracted as ransom payments.

In the north of the country the Kurdish forces kept control and maintained law and order. Reconstruction could proceed in this more secure situation. The oil wells increased their production and foreign companies invested in the development of the region. In the rest of Iraq, however, there was continuing lawlessness. In 2005 the Americans and their Iraqi allies in the government organised national elections. Most people voted along sectarian lines, i.e. for parties that represented their particular ethnic, usually religious, group or sect. As the Shiites made up 60 per cent of the population, most of their votes went to Shiite parties who thus won most of the seats in the Iraqi parliament.

The Sunni insurgency

Despite this democratic development the violence continued. The Sunnis, in particular, were prominent in the insurgency. They feared domination by the Shia majority. They were also fearful because most of Iraq's oil was in the Kurdish north or Shiite south. They were afraid of losing their economic, as well as their political, power. In 2005–6 there were a number of attacks on Shiite mosques. These may have been carried out by Iraqi Sunnis who feared a Shiite-dominated Iraq. Equally, they may have been carried out by bombers sympathetic to al-Qaida as part of their campaign to drive the Americans out of the Middle East by causing maximum destruction. It was difficult to know who was responsible for all the bombing in an increasingly lawless and violent country. Either way, the bombing of Shiite mosques led to retaliation: there were several attacks on Sunni mosques as well as reports that Shiites in the Iraqi police force were murdering Sunnis.

Nevertheless, there were some improvements and the situation was not wholly bleak. The hated regime of Saddam Hussein had been overthrown and, in 2006, he was tried and later executed for **'crimes against humanity'**, such as the gassing of the Kurds in 1988 (see page 127). A parliament was elected in 2005, a new Iraqi-run government was established and the police and armed forces were built up. By 2008, the daily death toll had decreased and the Iraqi authorities had largely taken control of their country. However, they still depended on the support of American troops; millions of Iraqis were unemployed; crime was rife and the provision of basic services like water, sewage and electricity was patchy. The recovery of Iraq continues to be a long process.

Key term

'Crimes against humanity' Widespread or systematic attack against a civilian population.